Techfest 2026-27

The India @ 71/100 Challenge

Objective:

India has made remarkable progress across education, healthcare, financial inclusion, and social welfare over the past decade. According to the **NITI Aayog SDG India Index 2023–24**, the country now scores **71 out of 100**, reflecting real, measurable gains.

But national averages often hide what's happening on the ground. Good policies exist; the gap lies in how well they reach the people who need them most. **The India @ 71/100 Challenge** invites students to close exactly this gap: identify where implementation is falling short, and design practical, scalable solutions that strengthen what already exists rather than reinventing it. Bring your ideas to life at **Techfest, IIT Bombay**, Asia's largest science and technology festivals.

The **India @ 71/100 Challenge** is a national innovation competition where participants identify a real implementation challenge within one of the three competition themes and propose a practical, evidence-based solution. Using research, credible data, and ground-level understanding, teams will develop solutions that are innovative, feasible, and scalable.

Challenge question

Identify one measurable gap between India's development scorecard and the lived reality of an underserved group (including socially marginalised groups) within one of the three competition themes, and design a solution that could be realistically implemented and scaled in the real world.

The challenge spans three themes; choose one and build a solution within it.

Theme 1: Maternal & Early Childhood Nutrition

Overview

India runs one of the world's largest maternal and child nutrition data ecosystems - Anganwadis, ASHA workers, and Poshan Abhiyaan/Mission Poshan 2.0 - yet

undernutrition remains one of the country's most persistent public health challenges. The ICDS-CAS/Poshan Tracker application already digitally tracks growth-monitoring and service-delivery indicators for close to 9 crore children. The implementation gap is therefore rarely an absence of data; it is that this data is not consistently governed, integrated, or acted upon in real time - it sits in siloed dashboards, is used mostly for retrospective reporting rather than early warning, and is not interoperable with the health system's own digital records. This theme asks participants to treat nutrition data as critical public infrastructure and design the data-governance and decision-support layer that policy intent alone cannot deliver.

Problem Statement

From a data governance and policy-implementation perspective, design a technologically robust solution that closes the gap between what Poshan Abhiyaan/Mission Poshan 2.0 already collects and what frontline systems actually act on.

Your solution must engage with at least one of the following:

1) Interoperability & data flow - how should Anganwadi (ICDS-CAS/Poshan Tracker), ASHA/health-system, and community-level records be linked or made interoperable so at-risk children are flagged before, not after, severe malnutrition develops?

2) Decision rights & accountability - who should see which data, at what frequency, and through what escalation protocol, so that a block or district administrator can act on early-warning signals within existing service-delivery timelines?

3) Data quality & governance safeguards - how should data validation, consent, and child-data privacy be built into the system design from the outset, consistent with applicable data-protection and data-sharing norms?

Participants are expected to submit a concrete technical architecture - a data pipeline, alerting or decision-support model, or platform design - and not a policy recommendation alone.

Suggested Data Sources & References:

- Poshan Tracker / ICDS-CAS dashboards, Ministry of Women & Child Development;
- National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), 2019-21, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare;
- Mission Poshan 2.0 guidelines, Ministry of Women & Child Development;

- Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission, National Health Authority - for health-data interoperability standards;
- Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 - for consent and data-governance obligations;
- National Data Governance Framework Policy, Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology, 2022 - for inter-agency data-sharing norms.

or

Theme 2: Foundational Learning Outcomes

Overview

India has achieved near-universal school enrolment, yet ASER 2024 and the government's own PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan (2024) confirm that a majority of children are not acquiring foundational reading and numeracy skills at their expected grade level. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the NIPUN Bharat Mission for Foundational Literacy and Numeracy already set clear policy targets, and India runs one of the world's largest school data systems through UDISE+. The implementation gap is less about missing data than about how policy-mandated assessment and attendance data is governed, aggregated, and converted into classroom-level and system-level decisions. This theme asks participants to close the gap between what schools already record and what actually changes for a struggling learner.

Problem Statement

From a data governance and policy-implementation perspective, design a technologically robust intervention that converts India's existing school data ecosystem (UDISE+, ASER, PARAKH, state assessment systems) into a decision-support system aligned with the NIPUN Bharat/FLN policy mandate.

Your solution must engage with at least one of the following:

1) Data governance & standardisation - how should attendance, assessment, and learning-level data be standardised and made interoperable across UDISE+, state assessment platforms, and classroom-level tools so a teacher, block official, and state administrator see a consistent picture?

2) Decision-support at point of use - how can existing data be surfaced as an actionable, low-bandwidth tool for teachers to identify and remediate specific learning gaps, rather than remaining a compliance report?

3) Policy-monitoring feedback loops - how should PARAKH/ASER-style diagnostic

data feed back into resource allocation, teacher training, or School Management Committee decisions at the block or district level?

Participants are expected to submit a concrete technical architecture - a data pipeline, diagnostic or analytics engine, or decision-support platform - grounded in these existing datasets, and not a generic ed-tech pitch.

Suggested Data Sources & References:

- ASER 2024, Annual Status of Education Report, ASER Centre/Pratham
- PARAKH Rashtriya Sarvekshan 2024, Ministry of Education / PARAKH (Performance Assessment, Review and Analysis of Knowledge for Holistic Development)
- UDISE+ (Unified District Information System for Education Plus), Ministry of Education
- National Education Policy (NEP) 2020
- NIPUN Bharat Mission for Foundational Literacy and Numeracy, Ministry of Education, 2021
- DIKSHA - National Digital Infrastructure for Teachers

or

Theme 3: Financial Inclusion & Meaningful Banking Access

Overview

India has dramatically expanded formal banking access through the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), bringing over 56 crore people into the financial system, and the RBI's Financial Inclusion Index (FI-Index) confirms steady national progress. Yet roughly a quarter of these accounts remain inactive, and usage of digital payments, credit, and DBT-linked benefits remains uneven across gender, geography, and literacy levels. The policy and data infrastructure for inclusion already exists - PMJDY, the DBT Mission, Aadhaar-enabled payments, and UPI - but converting formal access into meaningful, sustained usage requires better governance of the data these systems already generate. This theme is not about building new fintech products; it is about using the transaction, DBT, and account-status data already flowing through India's Digital Public Infrastructure to close the access-to-usage gap.

Problem Statement

From a data governance and policy-implementation perspective, design a technologically robust solution that uses existing financial-inclusion data - PMJDY

account and transaction status, DBT Mission records, RBI FI-Index indicators - to move beneficiaries from merely holding a formal account to actively and meaningfully using financial services.

Your solution must engage with at least one of the following:

1)Data-driven targeting & governance - how should dormancy, DBT-linkage, and usage data be governed and shared, within applicable RBI/NPCI/DBT Mission data-protection norms, to identify and prioritise specific inactive-account segments for intervention?

2) Interoperable last-mile infrastructure - how can Aadhaar-enabled payment systems, UPI, and Business Correspondent networks be better integrated with existing account data to reduce friction for low-literacy or rural users?

3) Policy feedback & accountability - how should account-activity data feed back into the National Strategy for Financial Inclusion targets so implementers can be held accountable for usage, not just enrollment?

Participants are expected to submit a concrete technical architecture - a data-driven targeting model, interoperable payment/access layer, or governance dashboard - and not a new financial product concept alone.

Suggested Data Sources & References:

- Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) dashboards, Department of Financial Services, Ministry of Finance
- RBI Financial Inclusion Index (FI-Index), Reserve Bank of India
- National Strategy for Financial Inclusion, Reserve Bank of India
- Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) Mission dashboards, DBT Bharat, Cabinet Secretariat
- National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) - UPI/AePS usage data
- Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 - for consent and data-sharing safeguards in financial data use

Objectives & Deliverables

Participants are expected to:

- **Identify a Measurable Implementation Gap:** Select a specific problem within one of the three competition themes where India's development indicators differ from the lived experiences of an underserved community.

- **Analyze the Existing Ecosystem:** Study current government schemes, public infrastructure, available datasets, or community initiatives addressing the problem, and identify why the implementation gap continues to persist.
- **Develop an Innovative Solution:** Design a practical intervention that strengthens existing systems through technology, process improvements, behavioural interventions, community participation, policy innovation, or other suitable approaches.
- **Demonstrate Feasibility:** Explain how the proposed solution can be realistically implemented, considering stakeholders, resources, operational constraints, and long-term sustainability.
- **Estimate Social Impact:** Clearly define the intended beneficiaries, expected outcomes, measurable impact, and the potential for scaling the solution beyond its initial implementation.

Competition Structure & Timeline

Eligibility & Team Rules

- **Team Size**: Maximum of 4 members per team.
- **Eligibility**: Open to all students with a valid institutional ID. Cross-institutional teams are permitted.
- Each team may register for **only one** theme.

Competition Format

Round 1: Concept Proposal Submission

This is the preliminary screening round where teams present their understanding of the problem and their proposed solution. The objective is to evaluate the significance of the identified implementation gap, the novelty of the proposed approach, and its overall feasibility.

The proposal should be concise and include:

- **Team Information:** Team Name, Team ID, Institution, and Contact Details.
- **Problem Identification:** The implementation gap selected within the chosen theme and the underserved community it affects.
- **Evidence & Context:** Supporting data, reports, or research demonstrating

the significance of the problem.
- **Existing Ecosystem:** Brief analysis of current schemes, initiatives, or solutions and the remaining implementation gap.
- **Proposed Solution:** A high-level description of the solution, explaining how it addresses the identified gap.
- **Expected Impact:** Intended beneficiaries and anticipated social impact.

The complete proposal should not exceed **6 pages** (A4, 1-inch margins, Arial font, minimum 11pt, single PDF file)

Submission: All Round 1 proposals must be submitted via the official Round 1 Google Form (link to be shared with registered teams). The form will require you to upload your documentation PDF. Ensure your PDF is named India71_100_[Team ID].pdf. Submissions via email will not be accepted.

Shortlist: Top **10** teams per theme (30 total) advance to Round 2.

Round 2: Final Presentation (Techfest, IIT Bombay)

Shortlisted teams will present a refined version of their proposal before an expert jury followed by a Q & A during Techfest, IIT Bombay.

The presentation should include:

- Problem validation and stakeholder understanding
- Existing ecosystem analysis
- Detailed solution
- Implementation roadmap
- Feasibility analysis
- Scalability
- Impact assessment

Each team will receive **10 minutes** for the presentation followed by a **5-minute** jury interaction. Winners are determined by jury scores. Decisions of organizers and judges are final and binding.

Key Dates

Event	Deadline

Registration closes	15th October
Round 1 submission	1st November
Shortlist announcement	8th November
Finals	16th - 18th December 2026

Evaluation, Prizes, and Recognition

Evaluation Criteria

Proposals and presentations are evaluated on the following, drawn directly from what teams are asked to submit across both rounds:

- **Problem Identification:** How clearly does the team define the implementation gap and the specific underserved community it affects?
- **Evidence & Context:** How well is the problem supported by credible data, reports, or research demonstrating its significance and scale?
- **Existing Ecosystem Analysis:** Has the team studied current government schemes, infrastructure, or community initiatives already addressing this problem, and clearly explained why the gap persists despite them?
- **Proposed Solution:** How well does the solution address the identified gap? Is the approach, whether technology, policy, process, or community-based, clearly explained?
- **Feasibility & Implementation Roadmap:** How realistic is the plan for implementation, considering stakeholders, resources, and operational constraints?
- **Impact & Scalability:** How clearly are the intended beneficiaries and expected outcomes defined, and how credible is the potential to scale the solution beyond its initial pilot?

General Rules

1. Teams must register online at techfest.org, receiving a Team ID for future reference.
2. The organizers' and judges' decisions are final and binding. Techfest reserves the right to verify participant details.
3. Techfest, IIT Bombay, is not responsible for late or lost entries.
4. Solutions must be original and not protected by patents, copyrights, or publications.

5. The latest information will be available on techfest.org, with registered participants notified of changes via email.
6. All technical, procedural, and competition-related queries must be submitted directly through the Techfest Competition Portal under the Doubt section. Participants are strictly requested to regularly check the portal for answers and updates
7. Official communication for important announcements will be through the email siddhi@techfest.org. Queries submitted via email will not be entertained

Certificate Policy

1. The top three teams per theme in Round 2 receive a **Certificate of Excellence**.
2. Only those teams that are shortlisted for the finals and also give a final presentation about their work during Techfest 2026-27 would be awarded an **E-Certificate of Participation**.

Prize Money

Prize money will be awarded to the **top three** teams via NEFT, latest by May 2027.

Prize Money Submission Process

- **Submission Channel:** Complete the prize money form **directly on the website** after the final round concludes. The winners will be able to view the form through their registered email ID
- **Deadline:** The form must be submitted by **December 31, 2026**.

Details Needed for the Website Form

When filling out the form on the website, make sure you have the following bank account details ready:

1. Account Holder's Name
2. Account Number
3. Bank Name and Branch Name
4. IFSC Code